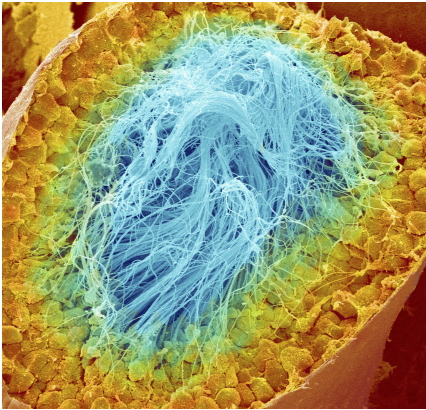




THIS IS **DAY 9 OF YOUR MENSTRUAL CYCLE**
271 days to go

WHAT'S HAPPENING INSIDE

In your partner's body, sperm is constantly being produced. Here the sperm cells can be seen: they consist of a head (green), which contains the genetic material, and fertilizes the egg, and a tail (blue), which propels the sperm along.

“While you wait to ovulate, fascinating changes are occurring in your ovaries as your follicles mature to release an egg.”

In the time leading up to ovulation, which will happen later this week, the most advanced follicle moves to the surface of the ovary, ready to release its precious cargo. While you were having your period, around 15–20 follicles were developing in your ovaries.

Both of your ovaries contribute to follicle growth, but in each cycle usually only one ovary brings a follicle to ovulation. This depends on chance since ovaries do not operate in a strict rotation. As the dominant follicle grows, it enlarges greatly, filling with fluid secreted inside the follicle. About 1 percent of women may release more than one egg some months (see [Multiple twin pregnancies](#)). If both are fertilized, nonidentical twins are conceived.

By the time of ovulation, the follicle will be about 1 in (2.5 cm) in diameter, while the egg is just about visible without a microscope.

To mature, follicles need FSH (follicle-stimulating hormone) produced by the brain's [pituitary gland](#), but their early growth doesn't appear to rely on it. It may, however, depend on other hormones and chemicals.

SPECIALIZED MEDICAL ADVICE

If you have an existing medical condition, it may affect your pregnancy, so seek medical advice before you conceive. If you are taking regular medication for diabetes, asthma, high blood pressure, heart trouble, [deep vein thrombosis \(DVT\)](#), thyroid conditions, sickle-cell disease, epilepsy, or any other ongoing medical condition, consult your doctor before you conceive. If you conceive while you are on medication, do not stop the treatment, but see your doctor immediately.

BOOSTING MALE FERTILITY

Sperm take some weeks to mature, so if you want to become a dad, eat a healthy diet at least two to three months before conception. Being overweight can adversely affect male fertility, so exercise and try to improve your diet.